

The MentorSphere

Equality, Diversity and Inclusion Policy

Version 2.0

Document details

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Policy owner	Luke Turner, Founder and Equality Lead

Public website: [View The MentorSphere policy directory](#)

Policy wording

1. Purpose

The MentorSphere is committed to providing services that are inclusive, accessible, respectful and free from unlawful discrimination.

This policy explains how equality, diversity and inclusion are incorporated into:

- Online Maths, English and Science tutoring
- ADHD and executive function coaching
- Education, SEND, EHE and EOTAS support
- EHCP guidance and document support
- Private examination and access arrangement support
- ADHD and autism referral preparation
- School, employer and organisation-funded work
- Any future service delivered under The MentorSphere
- The selection and management of cover tutors, contractors and temporary staff

The policy applies to prospective, current and former clients; learners; parents and guardians; employees; contractors; partner organisations; and anyone interacting with The MentorSphere.

2. Our commitment

The MentorSphere aims to:

- Treat every person with dignity, fairness and respect
- Provide equitable access to services and information
- Recognise that fair treatment does not always mean identical treatment
- Make reasonable adjustments where a person faces a disability-related barrier
- Respect different identities, cultures, family structures, communication styles and life experiences
- Challenge discrimination, harassment, bullying and victimisation
- Create emotionally safe and neurodiversity-affirming learning and coaching environments
- Make decisions transparently and for legitimate service, safeguarding or professional reasons
- Ensure that no one is disadvantaged for requesting an adjustment or raising a concern in good faith

The MentorSphere welcomes clients from all backgrounds. A diagnosis, formal educational plan or medical report is not generally required before someone can discuss their needs or request an adjustment.

3. Equality framework

The Equality Act 2010 identifies the following protected characteristics across its different legal contexts:

- Age
- Disability
- Gender reassignment
- Marriage and civil partnership
- Pregnancy and maternity
- Race, including colour, nationality and ethnic or national origin
- Religion or belief
- Sex
- Sexual orientation

The precise legal protection attached to each characteristic may vary according to the context in which a service is being provided.

The MentorSphere's organisational commitment extends beyond the minimum legal requirements. Unfair treatment will not be accepted because of a person's:

- Neurotype or suspected neurodivergence
- Gender identity or expression
- Family structure or caring responsibilities
- Socio-economic background
- Educational route, including home education or alternative provision
- Communication style
- Mental health history
- Recovery history
- Care experience
- Appearance, accent or first language
- Any other personal characteristic or circumstance unrelated to their suitability for the service

4. Fair access to services

Enquiries, assessments, bookings and service decisions will be handled fairly.

A decision to accept, decline, pause or end a service may legitimately be based on factors including:

- Whether the service is suitable for the person's age and needs
- Whether the requested work falls within The MentorSphere's competence and professional boundaries
- Availability and capacity
- Safeguarding or safety concerns
- Conflicts of interest
- Whether the service can be delivered effectively online
- Repeated non-payment
- Repeated breaches of agreed booking or conduct terms
- Behaviour that presents a genuine risk to the learner, tutor or another person

Such decisions will not be made unlawfully because of a protected characteristic.

Where The MentorSphere cannot safely or appropriately meet a person's needs, this will be explained sensitively. Reasonable signposting may be offered, but The MentorSphere cannot guarantee the availability or suitability of another provider.

5. Pricing and funding arrangements

Prices may vary according to:

- The type and length of service

- Whether the work is self-funded, employer-funded, school-funded or funded through Access to Work
- The amount of preparation, administration, liaison or reporting required
- Whether the work forms part of a package or separately commissioned project
- The agreed scope and complexity of the work

Prices will not be increased, reduced or otherwise varied because of a protected characteristic.

Any substantive additional work, including detailed reports, extensive document reviews or external liaison, will be discussed and priced before that work begins.

6. Reasonable adjustments and accessibility

The MentorSphere will consider reasonable adjustments where a disabled person or someone with an additional need would otherwise experience a substantial barrier.

Adjustments may include:

- Camera-off participation
- Additional or planned breaks
- Shorter sessions or a differently structured session
- Reduced written administration
- A verbal-first approach
- Additional processing time
- Slower pacing or repetition
- Alternative colours, fonts, layouts or visual presentation
- Written information in a clearer or simplified format
- Use of assistive technology
- Flexible methods of communication
- Parent or guardian involvement where appropriate
- Advance information about what a session will involve
- Changes to the balance between discussion, visual activities and written work

Requests will be considered individually. The person requesting an adjustment may be asked what barrier they are experiencing and what change would help.

The MentorSphere may not always be able to provide the exact adjustment requested. An adjustment may be declined where it would:

- Compromise safeguarding or confidentiality
- Create an unacceptable safety risk
- Fundamentally change the nature of the commissioned service
- Require work outside The MentorSphere's competence
- Place a disproportionate burden on the service
- Conflict with another person's legitimate rights or needs

Where possible, an alternative adjustment will be discussed.

Reasonable adjustments themselves will not attract an additional charge. Separately commissioned work, additional session time or substantial report writing may be chargeable where the cost relates to the additional service rather than to the adjustment itself.

7. Neurodiversity-affirming practice

The MentorSphere recognises neurodiversity as part of natural human variation.

Support will focus on understanding the individual rather than forcing conformity to a single idea of appropriate learning, communication or behaviour.

The service aims to avoid:

- Shame-based approaches
- Unnecessary compliance demands
- Treating neurodivergent traits as deliberate defiance
- Assuming that one strategy will work for everyone
- Requiring eye contact, camera use or stillness without a legitimate reason
- Defining success solely through grades, productivity or outward behaviour
- Speaking about a young person without appropriately involving them

Strategies will be developed collaboratively and may draw on strengths, interests, sensory preferences, communication needs and personal goals.

The MentorSphere is also LGBTQIA+ affirmative, trauma-aware and recovery-informed.

8. Names, pronouns and personal identity

A person's chosen name and pronouns will be respected.

Information about identity, disability, diagnosis, health or personal circumstances will be treated confidentially and shared only where:

- Consent has been provided
- Sharing is necessary to deliver the agreed service
- A safeguarding concern or serious risk of harm exists
- Disclosure is required by law

Accidental mistakes will be corrected respectfully. Deliberate or repeated disrespectful behaviour may be addressed under this policy and the Complaints Policy.

9. Harassment, discrimination and unacceptable conduct

The following will not be accepted within sessions, communications or other interactions:

- Discriminatory language or conduct
- Harassment or sexual harassment
- Bullying or victimisation
- Deliberate misuse of names or pronouns
- Racist, homophobic, transphobic, sexist, ableist or religiously intolerant behaviour
- Threatening, degrading or humiliating treatment
- Retaliation against someone who has raised an equality concern

This applies to conduct by The MentorSphere, learners, family members, staff, contractors and third parties involved in the service.

Where inappropriate conduct may be connected to disability, communication difficulty, emotional dysregulation or another relevant need, this will be considered before action is taken. This does not mean that threatening, abusive or unsafe behaviour must be accepted.

The response may include:

- A calm discussion or reminder
- Changes to communication or session arrangements
- A behaviour or safety agreement
- Involvement of a parent, guardian, employer or commissioning organisation
- Pausing the service
- Ending the service where the conduct is serious or continues despite proportionate intervention
- Safeguarding or external reporting where necessary

10. Staff, contractors and cover tutors

Selection decisions will be based on relevant factors such as:

- Experience and competence
- Safeguarding suitability
- Qualifications where required
- Understanding of inclusive and neurodiversity-affirming practice
- Ability to meet the requirements of the role
- Professional conduct and reliability

Unlawful discrimination will not form part of recruitment, selection, allocation or progression decisions.

Anyone providing services on behalf of The MentorSphere must follow this policy.

11. Raising an equality concern

Concerns should be raised as soon as reasonably possible with:

Luke Turner
Founder and Equality Lead
Email: luke@thementorsphere.co.uk
Telephone: 07955 723 133

A concern may be raised verbally or in writing. Alternative communication arrangements can be requested.

Equality-related complaints will be handled under the Complaints Policy. Safeguarding concerns will be prioritised and handled under the Safeguarding Policy.

No person will receive less favourable treatment for raising a genuine concern, supporting another person's complaint or requesting an adjustment.

12. Monitoring and review

The MentorSphere will use feedback, complaints, adjustment requests and service experience to identify possible improvements.

This policy will be reviewed:

- At least annually
- Following a significant equality-related complaint
- When legislation or official guidance changes
- When staffing or service arrangements materially change
- When monitoring identifies an accessibility or inclusion problem

13. Related policies

This policy should be read alongside:

- Complaints Policy
- Safeguarding Policy
- Privacy Policy
- SEND, SEMH and Neurodiversity Policy
- ADHD Coaching Policy
- Technical Requirements and Troubleshooting Policy
- Cover Tutor and Temporary Staff Policy
- Current pricing, booking and cancellation terms
- Accessibility Statement

14. Change log

Version 2.0, 30 July 2026: replaced the former Maths Mentor-only policy; extended the scope across The MentorSphere; updated contact details, service coverage, reasonable adjustments, neurodiversity-affirming practice and links to current policies.

This policy does not limit any person's statutory rights or protections under equality law.